

STAGE SIXTEEN • WORKPLACE PROFESSIONALISM & ETHICS

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Sixteen • Workplace Professionalism & Workplace Readiness / Professional Ethics & Integrity

PURPOSE

Stage Sixteen runs across five sessions — Workplace Fundamentals, Navigating Workplace Situations, Performance & Professional Identity, Ethical Foundations & Responsibilities, and Applied Ethics & Integrity Reflection — each gets one icebreaker below, built directly from that session's actual content.

The Session 4 and 5 openers are deliberately lower-key and more reflective than the earlier ones, matching the more emotionally weighted material those sessions cover. Neither asks for real personal disclosure — they use hypothetical scenarios or low-stakes personal patterns to warm up the specific kind of thinking those sessions require.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Five Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

The Unwritten Rule

TIME: 10 min

1. Ask each participant to think of one unwritten rule at a workplace, school, or team they've been part of — something never officially stated but everyone somehow knew.
2. Quick round-robin, one unwritten rule each, no elaboration needed.
3. Facilitator asks: how did you actually learn it? (Usually: getting it wrong once, or watching someone else get it wrong.)

WHY THIS WORKS

This surfaces, before any formal teaching, exactly what FIRST T3 (Workplace Etiquette Awareness) is built on — that real workplace norms are often unwritten and have to be actively observed, not assumed.

SESSION 2

The Almost-Escalation

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask the group: “think of a time you almost raised an issue to someone above you, but didn't.”
2. In pairs, share what held you back — not the issue itself, just the hesitation.
3. Quick full-group tally: how many hesitations were about fear of seeming unable to handle it alone, versus not knowing who to actually ask?

WHY THIS WORKS

This produces, in the group's own experience, the exact tension FIRST T14 (Workplace Escalation) is designed to resolve — the two competing failure modes of avoiding escalation or escalating vaguely.

SESSION 3

The Feedback You Never Got

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask each participant to silently think of one piece of feedback they wish someone had given them sooner, in any context.
2. In pairs, share it, and share what you think held that person back from saying it.
3. Facilitator collects a few themes from the room without naming individuals.

WHY THIS WORKS

This sets up FIRST T19 (Workplace Feedback Request) by making the cost of not asking for feedback — or not receiving it — immediately concrete and personal.

SESSION 4

The Gray Area

TIME: 10 min

1. Present a genuinely ambiguous, low-stakes ethical scenario (e.g., “you notice a coworker taking slightly longer breaks than allowed, but their work is excellent — do you say anything?”).
2. Quick show of hands: who would say something, who wouldn't, who's genuinely unsure?
3. Ask one person from each group to briefly explain their reasoning, without pressure to defend it extensively.

WHY THIS WORKS

This demonstrates, before any formal framework is introduced, that genuine ethical dilemmas rarely have an obvious answer — directly previewing FIRST T35 (Ethical Dilemma Analysis).

SESSION 5

The Standard You Actually Live By

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask each participant to complete this sentence in their head: “regardless of what anyone checks, I always ___.”
2. In pairs, share your completed sentence.
3. Quick full-group observation: notice how specific or vague these were — facilitator flags this without singling anyone out.

WHY THIS WORKS

This is a direct, low-stakes rehearsal of the exact reflection FIRST T44 (Professional Responsibility Statement) and T45 (Integrity Audit) will ask for later in the session, at higher stakes.